Saturday, 23 February 2008

We are playing in Bangladesh and we're in trouble. After the high of coming from behind to secure a 2–1 win in the home Test series against the West Indies and then sweeping the ODI series by five matches to nil, we are being put under pressure by the emerging Test nation in front of their own supporters.

It's early on the second day of the first Test at the Shere Bangla Stadium in Mirpur and, in reply to the home team's first innings of 192, we are resuming under pressure at 76 for four ... and that soon becomes 77 for five when Ashwell Prince is run out. As the next man in, I join Johan Botha at the crease.

The pitch is slow and the occasional ball keeps low, so I am careful but decide to counter-attack, and proceed to pull, cut and drive, at one point heaving Shakib Al Hasan over mid-wicket for six.

Johan and I are slowly turning the tide of the Test. Our total has reached 145 for five, and, on 46, I am facing the right-arm off-breaks of Mohammad Ashraful. The ball pitches short – so short that it actually bounces twice. I aim to swipe the ball away to leg, but it loops up off a leading edge and is caught by the bowler. There is a loud appeal and umpire Steve Bucknor, one of the best on the circuit, gives me out.

No way, that must be a no ball. I stand my ground. It's got to be called a no ball if the ball bounces twice, doesn't it? I'm sure that's the rule. As far as I know, that's the rule. That was certainly the rule when we played garden cricket at 20 Mentz Avenue. I wait around and ask the other umpire, Aleem Dar. You're out, he says.

Seriously? I'm not happy as I head back to the pavilion. In fact, the umpires are right and I am wrong. Law 24 clearly states that a no ball must be called if the ball bounces *more than twice*; it bounced only twice, so I am out.

'Well, if that's the law, it's a bad law,' I mutter.

We eventually reach 170 and then dismiss Bangladesh for 182, with